

IDEAS

STEPPE BELIEFS

Steppe peoples were heavily influenced by the expansive skies of the open steppelands, which, as a major navigational guide, played a huge role in their lives. Some peoples certainly believed in a sky deity, a “heaven,” and an afterlife, and shamanistic practices may also have been widespread. Shamans are people thought to have the power to cure sickness and communicate with the spirit world. Mirrors, a traditional shamanic tool, are believed to reflect secret truths and ward off evil spirits.

MONGOLIAN
SHAMAN'S
MIRROR



many raids were small affairs. The popular idea of invading hordes is misleading—a few fierce horsemen galloping in would seem overwhelming to an agricultural village.

Scythian and Kushans

The Scythians were a group of steppe peoples who had migrated from Central Asia to southern Russia by the 7th century BCE. Their warriors fought with bows and arrows, and axes. They wore felt caps and, except for some members of the aristocracy, no armor.

The Scythians possessed sizable territories at different periods, including a large area of the Middle East. One group, the “Royal Scythes,” controlled an area around southern Russia, where stunning grave finds of gold artifacts point to a well-developed Scythian culture. By the 2nd century CE, the Scythians had been quashed by the Sarmatians, who were in turn defeated by the Huns (see pp.150–51).

THE AMAZONS, the famous female warriors of Greco-Roman legend, may have been based on Eurasian steppe women, who some believe took an active role in raiding and fighting.



Kushan head

This sculpture shows the mix of Greco-Roman and Indian influences that infused much of Kushan art.

Steppe nomads often integrated with people living in areas they invaded.

In the 1st–3rd centuries CE, for example, the Kushans migrated from the fringes of

Mongolia to the western steppe, into lands that once formed part of the Achaemenid Persian Empire (see pp.92–93) and the empire of Alexander the Great (see pp.96–98). Like the Parthians (see pp.122–23), the Kushans developed a settled, sophisticated culture that readily incorporated Greek, Persian, and Indian influences.

The Xiongnu

Xiongnu (or Hsiung-nu) is a term for a loose grouping of different steppe peoples (including some Scythians) whose warriors were raiding China by the 3rd century BCE. Some aspects of their culture seem to have been adopted from the Chinese regimes they attacked. The Xiongnu were a dominant force in Central Asia for five centuries.

Steppe peoples continued to make their mark on groups across Eurasia, from displaced Germanic tribes to rising Islamic powers.

THE HUNS

Between the 4th and 5th centuries CE, pastoral steppe nomads known as Huns **controlled**



HUN DINARS

Huge swaths of Europe

and Asia, conquering other tribes they encountered, including the Germanic Ostrogoths. In the mid-5th century, some of those peoples **fought back** successfully against the Huns, and the **Eastern Roman Empire** also closed its borders. The Huns were soon a **spent force**.

TURKIC TRIBES

By c. 500 CE, the Turkic people (originally nomads in the Altai Mountains) **dominated much of the Asian steppe**. By c. 700 CE, their power had been weakened, and various Turkic tribes scattered westward following **wars with the Tang Chinese 160–61** >>. However, they remained a major presence, playing a key role in Middle Eastern history and the rise of Islam.

RISE OF THE MONGOLS

The Mongols managed to conquer and create a confederacy of all the nomads on the Mongolian steppes in the early 13th century **164–65** >>.

bow and stirrups. The composite bow is a short bow that is easy to fire from a horse, yet very powerful. The stirrup, which probably originated on the steppes around the 2nd century BCE, made it easier to ride well in full armor.

Steppe armies were skilled at launching sudden mounted attacks—usually raids rather than attempts at territorial conquest—and overran rival settlements with ease. Although some campaigns, such as the Cimmerian attack on Asia Minor c. 690 BCE, were large-scale onslaughts,

